



Colorado Early Learning

—●—●—●—●—●—●—

& Development Guidelines





Ages 3-5



Ages 3-5

The content for the 3 -5 age group is anchored on the 2015 Early Learning Outcomes Framework (ELOF). This content was then aligned to the 2020 Preschool Colorado Academic Standards (CAS). For instances in which content exists in the CAS but not in the ELOF, these indicators were added to each domain. Each early learning and development domain is introduced with a brief narrative overview discussing what is expected for children within this age group. Development during this age group should be viewed as a progression. The indicators should be expected by age 5 years and the examples are behaviors you might see at any time during this age range depending on a child's development.

Indicators that are aligned to the Colorado Academic Standards are noted with an asterisk (*) throughout each domain.

Physical Development & Health

The Physical Development & Health domain describes children's physical well-being, knowledge of their body, health, safety, nutrition practices, and development of motor skills. Children who have health problems, delays in development, and frequent illness may suffer from a range of poor educational outcomes. Children's knowledge of their body and health impact their development of healthy habits early in life, habits which are key to life-long health. This domain includes skills that enable children to develop healthy habits, such as staying safe, performing self-care tasks independently of others, exercising, and eating healthy food. The development of motor skills allows children to explore and learn about their world and develop healthy bodies.





Physical Development & Health		
Indicators Children may . . .	Examples Children may. . .	Suggested Supports Adults may . . .
1. Health, Safety and Nutrition: The maintenance of healthy and age appropriate physical well-being, and understanding of healthy and safe habits and practicing healthy habits.		
1. Possess good overall health, including oral, visual, and auditory health, and be free from communicable or preventable diseases. 2. Participate in prevention and management of chronic health conditions and avoid toxins, such as lead. 3. Maintain physical growth within the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC) recommended ranges for weight by height by age. 4. Get sufficient rest and exercise to support healthy development.* 5. Complete personal care tasks, such as dressing, brushing teeth, toileting, and washing hands independently from adults.* 6. Communicate an understanding of the importance of health and safety routines and rules.* 7. Follow basic health and safety rules and respond appropriately to harmful or unsafe situations.* 8. Distinguish food on a continuum from most healthy to less healthy. 9. Eat a variety of nutritious foods. 10. Participate in structured and unstructured physical activities.* 11. Recognize the importance of doctor and dentist visits. 12. Cooperate during doctor and dentist visits and health and developmental screening.	• Participate in games, outdoor play, and other forms of exercise to enhance physical fitness. • Play visual and auditory discrimination games such as "I spy" and take listening walks. • Participate in health education for families and children. • Follow consistent routines regarding washing hands. • Brainstorm all the ways teeth are important (e.g., appearance, chewing, talking). • Listen to stories about teeth, losing teeth. • Grow vegetables in a garden. • Help to prepare a variety of healthy snacks and meals, and talk about ingredients. • Create books, charts, collages, or displays with pictures of healthy/unhealthy foods, or a picture menu of health food choices. • Talk about the nutritional value of various foods and the relationship between a healthy diet and overall health and fitness.	• Identify and use local health, medical, and dental resources. • Encourage vision and hearing screening. • Make sure children are properly dressed for weather conditions and activities. • Ensure safety of children through adherence to state and local regulations. • Protect children from abuse and neglect. • Establish routines for eating, rest, and bedtime. • Aim for 10-13 hours of sleep per day (including naps). • Turn off the television and other screens one hour before bedtime and make the child's room a screen-free zone. • Help the child sleep with a cool room (less than 75 degrees). If the child appears to have trouble breathing, snores, or is restless with frequent kicking during sleep, contact the child's doctor. • Encourage children to show independence in self-care tasks, helping when necessary (e.g., brushing teeth, wiping nose, dressing, toileting, washing hands, feeding oneself). • Teach and model basic health and safety rules (e.g., washing hands, covering mouth when coughing or sneezing, taking care when using sharp objects, looking both ways before crossing streets, and wearing a helmet when bicycling). • Discuss with children appropriate responses to potentially dangerous situations and teach safety rules (e.g., bus safety, playground safety, staying with the group, knowing personal identification information, fire drills). • Secure adequate nutrition for children and introduce children to a variety of healthy foods. • Provide time for physical activity.



Physical Development & Health		
Indicators Children may . . .	Examples Children may. . .	Suggested Supports Adults may . . .
2. Gross Motor Skills: The control of large muscles for movement, navigation, and balance.		
1. Develop motor control and balance for a range of physical activities, such as walking, propelling a wheelchair or mobility device, skipping, running, climbing, and hopping.* 2. Develop motor coordination and skill in using objects for a range of physical activities, such as pulling, throwing, catching, kicking, bouncing or hitting balls, and riding a tricycle. 3. Understand movement concepts, such as control of the body, how the body moves (such as an awareness of space and directionality), and that the body can move independently or in coordination with other objects.*	• Walk, run, hop, or gallop when moving from one place to another. • Balance on one leg. • Pretend to be various jumping or crawling creatures (e.g., rabbit, frog, kangaroo, grasshopper, snake, lizard). • Combine large muscle movements with equipment (e.g., riding a tricycle, using a slide or swings, bouncing a ball). • Engage in activities that involve climbing, rocking, swinging, rolling, spinning, jumping, or being turned upside-down.	• Make physical activity a big part of children's daily life. • Provide adequate space and age-appropriate equipment and materials, with adaptations as needed. • Supervise and participate in daily outdoor play. • Plan daily physical activities that are vigorous as well as developmentally and individually appropriate. • Provide appropriate modifications for children with special needs.
3. Fine Motor Skills: The control of small muscles for such purposes as using utensils, self-care, building, and exploring.		
1. Develop hand strength and dexterity. 2. Develop eye-hand coordination to use everyday tools, such as pitchers for pouring or utensils for eating. 3. Manipulate a range of objects, such as blocks or books. 4. Manipulate writing, drawing, and art tools.	• Engage in activities that enhance hand-eye coordination, such as using eating utensils, dressing themselves, building with blocks, creating with clay or play dough, putting puzzles together, and stringing beads. • Link paper clips to make necklaces. • Create puppet shows with finger puppets.	• Provide adequate time for drawing, cutting, and handwriting development. • Provide modeling materials (e.g., play dough, clay) and activities (e.g., beads, Legos, small blocks) to strengthen hand and develop fine motor coordination. • Provide handheld tools, such as spoons, paintbrushes, crayons, markers, tweezers, eyedroppers, garlic press, clothespins, and safety scissors, with adaptations as needed. • Provide adaptive writing utensils for children with fine motor delays. • Show child how you use drawing and writing tools in your daily activities.

Social & Emotional Development

The Social & Emotional domain describes children’s ability to develop positive relationships and ideas about themselves and their abilities, regulate their emotions, behavior, and impulses, and express emotions. Appropriate social and emotional development is critical to life-long development and learning and is associated with a wide array of positive outcomes. Such skills allow children to feel confident in their abilities to interact with others, approach new situations, and express their individuality. Children who are English language learners should be allowed to express their emotions and relationships in their home language.





Social & Emotional Development		
Indicators Children may . . .	Examples Children may. . .	Suggested Supports Adults may . . .
1. Relationships with Adults and Peers: The healthy relationships and interactions with adults and peers.		
- Engage in and maintains positive relationships and interactions with adults.* - Engage in prosocial and cooperative behavior with adults.* - Engage in and maintains positive interactions and relationships with other children.* - Engage in cooperative play with other children. - Use basic problem-solving skills to resolve conflicts with other children.	- Interact readily with trusted adults. - Engage in some positive interactions with less familiar adults, such as parent volunteers. - Show affection and preference for adults who interact with them on a regular basis. - Seek help from adults when needed. - Engage in prosocial behaviors with adults, such as using respectful language or greetings. - Attend to an adult when asked. - Follow adult guidelines and expectations for appropriate behavior. - Ask or waits for adult permission before doing something when they are unsure. - Engage in and maintain positive interactions with other children. - Use a variety of skills for entering social situations with other children, such as suggesting something to do together, joining an existing activity, or sharing a toy. - Take turns in conversations and interactions with other children. - Develop friendships with one or two preferred other children. - Engage in joint play, such as using coordinated goals, planning, roles, and games with rules, with at least one other child at a time. - Demonstrate willingness to include others' ideas during interactions and play. - Show enjoyment of play with other children, such as through verbal exchanges, smiles, and laughter. - Engage in reflection and conversation about past play experiences. - Recognize and describe basic social problems in books or pictures, such as both children wanting the same toy, and during interactions with other children, such as "Why do you think your friend might be sad?" - Use basic strategies for dealing with common conflicts, such as sharing, taking turns, and compromising. - Express feelings, needs, and opinions in conflict situations. - Seek adult help when needed to resolve conflicts.	- Remember the details concerning the lives of individual children. For example, make a connection to their families by asking children to talk about the people in their drawings or photos. As time permits, use index cards or sentence strips to create captions. - Show children you value their presence by offering a warm, personal greeting when they enter the setting and a "See you tomorrow" or "See you soon" as they leave. When a child is absent, let her know you missed her. - See and be seen. Circulate so you can spot children who might need support. Make sure children can see you, too. - Pair a child who has difficulty making friends with a more skilled buddy to complete a fun activity together. - Model ways a child can invite himself into a group. Join the play yourself with dialogue that shows how; for example, "That looks like fun. Shall we ask them if we can play, too?" - Identify problems as you see them happening. Cue children by saying, "I see we have a problem. What should we do?" - Use puppets and persona dolls to role-play common conflicts, asking children to describe how characters are feeling and how they might solve the problem. - Create laminated books showing illustrated solutions to problems, such as trading, taking turns, and playing together. Have children refer to the book for solutions as needed. - Create a "friendship can" that includes popsicle sticks with each child's name or photo. Draw sticks to pair children for activities or classroom errands.



Social & Emotional Development		
Indicators Children may . . .	Examples Children may . . .	Suggested Supports Adults may . . .
2. Sense of Identity and Belonging: The perception that one is capable of successfully making decisions, accomplishing tasks, and meeting goals.		
1. Recognize self as a unique individual having own abilities, characteristics, emotions, and interests.* 2. Express confidence in own skills and positive feelings about self.* 3. Have a sense of belonging to family, community, and other groups.	• Describe self using several different characteristics. • Demonstrate knowledge of uniqueness of self, such as talents, interests, preferences, or culture. • Show satisfaction or seek acknowledgment when completing a task or solving a problem. • Express own ideas or beliefs in group contexts or in interactions with others. • Use positive words to describe self, such as kind or hard-worker. • Identify self as being a part of different groups, such as family, community, culture, faith, or preschool. • Relate personal stories about being a part of different groups. • Identify similarities and differences about self across familiar environments and settings.	• Take photos of children working and playing together and post them around the room. Share children's accomplishments with families via photos on protected websites or apps designed for this purpose. • Learn words and phrases in a child's home language that are meaningful to the child and family. • Have families bring in objects that represent children's cultures; for example, empty food boxes to stock the dramatic play area. • Offer chances for children to share information about themselves, their family, culture, and community; for example, drawing pictures, telling personal stories, and singing a song or doing a dance they learned at home or a community event.
3. Emotional Functioning: A healthy range of emotional expression and learning positive alternatives to aggressive or isolating behaviors.		
1. Express a broad range of emotions and recognize these emotions in self and others.* 2. Express care and concern toward others. 3. Manage emotions with increasing independence.*	• Recognize and labels basic emotions in books or photographs. • Use words or signs to describe own feelings. • Use words or signs to describe the feelings of adults or other children. • Reflect on personal experiences that evoked strong emotions. • Experiment with new materials and activities without fear of making mistakes. • Act out powerful emotions (fear, anger) through dramatic play.	• Pause before you react to an incident in the setting; for example, a disagreement over a turn on the slide. Ask the children who were involved how they feel about what has happened. This acknowledges children's feelings and also gives you a moment to figure out how you want to respond. • Encourage children to notice each other's feelings and suggest ways to help. "Jared, can you slide a little this way? Samantha is building something with blocks and looks worried that it may get knocked over." • Anticipate what might happen in a new situation and provide reassurance that will help children manage emotions. For example, "We have new supplies in the art center, and I know you will all want to try them out. Don't worry. Everyone will get a turn at some point during center time."



Social & Emotional Development		
Indicators Children may . . .	Examples Children may. . .	Suggested Supports Adults may . . .
4. Emotional and Behavioral Self-Regulation: The ability to recognize and regulate emotions and behavior.		
1. Follow classroom rules and routines with increasing independence.* 2. Appropriately handle and take care of classroom materials.* 3. Manage actions, words, and behavior with increasing independence.*	• Express emotions in ways that are appropriate to the situation. • Look for adult assistance when emotions are most intense. • Use a range of coping strategies to manage emotions with the support of an adult, such as using words or taking deep breaths. • Demonstrate awareness of classroom rules when asked and is able to follow these rules most of the time. • Follow most classroom routines, such as putting away their backpack when entering the room or sitting on the rug after outside time. • Respond to signals when transitioning from one activity to another. • Appropriately handle materials during activities. • Clean up and put materials away appropriately, such as placing blocks back on correct shelf or placing markers in the correct bin. • Demonstrate control over actions and words in response to a challenging situation, such as wanting to use the same materials as another child, or frustration over not being able to climb to the top of a structure. May need support from adults. • Manage behavior according to expectations, such as using quiet feet when asked or sitting on the rug during circle time. • Wait for their turn, such as wait in line to wash hands or wait for turn on swings. • Refrain from aggressive behavior towards others. • Begin to understand the consequences of behavior, such as hitting leads to quiet time. Children can describe the effects their behavior may have on others, such as noticing that another child feels sad when you hit him.	• Redirect challenging behavior by using different strategies, such as verbal reminders to suggest an alternative; physical cues (e.g., placing a hand on the shoulder of a child who's about to hit or grab a toy); visual cues (e.g., pointing to a rule on a chart); or calling attention to a child's who's doing what's expected. • Help children identify when they're tense and stressed, or relaxed and calm. Name those feelings when you see them. • Introduce the idea of taking three deep breaths as a calming technique. Children can use the mantra "smell the flowers" (inhale) and "blow out the candles" (exhale). Teach and practice when children are calm, and coach them when they're upset. • Set three to five rules that are simple and positively worded (e.g., "Hands to self; safe feet; eyes are watching; ears are listening; I try new things."). • Use pictures or photos to illustrate the rules. • Model what following the rules looks like. Acknowledge when children follow the rules (e.g., "Zenobia is sitting on the rug. She looks like she is ready for story time."). • Label shelves, bins, and containers with pictures and words so children know where to store toys and materials. Show children how to use and store them appropriately.



Social & Emotional Development

Indicators Children may . . .	Examples Children may . . .	Suggested Supports Adults may . . .
5. Cognitive Self-Regulation (Executive Functioning): The ability to regulate attention and impulses.		
1. Demonstrate an increasing ability to control impulses.* 2. Maintain focus and sustain attention with minimal adult support.* 3. Persist in tasks.* 4. Hold information in mind and manipulate it to perform tasks.* 5. Demonstrate flexibility in thinking and behavior.*	• Stop an engaging activity to transition to another less desirable activity with adult guidance and support. • Delay having desires met, such as agreeing to wait their turn to start an activity. • Without adult reminders, wait to communicate information to a group. • Refrain from responding impulsively, such as waiting to be called on during group discussion or requesting materials rather than grabbing them. • Maintain focus on activities for extended periods of time, such as 15 minutes or more. • Engage in purposeful play for extended periods of time. • Attend to adult during large and small group activities with minimal support. • Complete tasks that are challenging or less preferred despite frustration, either by persisting or seeking help from an adult or other child. • Return with focus to an activity or project after having been away from it. • Accurately recount recent experiences in the correct order and includes relevant details. • Successfully follow detailed, multi-step directions, sometimes with reminders. • Remember actions to go with stories or songs shortly after being taught. • Try different strategies to complete work or solve problems, including with other children. • Apply different rules in contexts that require different behaviors, such as using indoor voices or feet instead of outdoor voices or feet. • Transition between activities without getting upset.	• Play games, such as Simon Says or freeze dance, where children are challenged to control impulses and hold information in mind and use it to perform a task. • Praise children's attempts to regulate or control their impulses (e.g., "Jeremy, thank you for remembering to raise your hand so everyone gets a turn.>"). • Use external aids to support children's attention and memory. For example: 1. Invite children to plan which learning center they will play in, and give them a card with a picture of the learning center. 2. In buddy reading, pair one child who holds a card indicating they want to hear a story with a child who holds a card indicating that they would like to read a story. • Assist a frustrated child by providing just enough help (e.g., "You are working so hard on that puzzle! Would that piece fit if you turned it a little bit?"). • Use prompts to help children connect new concepts with what was learned previously (e.g., "Remember when ...," "Yesterday ...," and "What does this remind you of?"). • Ask children to generate ideas and try them out (e.g., "How could we use these materials to build a birdhouse?").